Nature of News



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What is the similarity between a geologist and journalist?





WHAT NEWS IS

The criteria that professional reporters and editors use to decide what news is can be summarized in three words:

- Relevance
- Usefulness
- Interest

Elements of a Good News Story

Reporters seek more specific elements in each potential story. The most important elements are these:

- Impact
- Conflict
- Novelty
- Prominence
- Proximity
- Timeliness
- Engagement
- Solutions

Source: Textbook on News Reporting and Writing by The Missouri Group

Impact

- The potential impact of a story is another way of measuring its relevance and usefulness.
- How many people are affected by an event or idea?
- How seriously does it affect them?
- The wider and heavier the impact, the better the story. Sometimes, of course, impact isn't immediately obvious.
- Sometimes it isn't very exciting.
- The challenge for good journalism is making such dull but important stories lively and interesting.
- That may require relying on the next three elements.

Source: Textbook on News Reporting and Writing by The Missouri Group

Conflict

- Conflict is a recurring theme in all storytelling, whether the stories told are journalism, literature or drama.
- Struggles between people, among nations or with natural forces make fascinating reading and viewing.
- Conflict is such a basic element of life that journalists must resist the temptation to overdramatize or oversimplify it.

Source: Textbook on News Reporting and Writing by The Missouri Group

Novelty

- Novelty is another element common to journalism and other kinds of stories.
- People or events may be interesting and therefore newsworthy just because they are unusual or bizarre.

Source: Textbook on News Reporting and Writing by The Missouri Group

Prominence

- Names make news. The bigger the name, the bigger the news.
- Ordinary people have always been intrigued by the doings of the rich and famous.
- Both prominence and novelty can be, and often are, exaggerated to produce "news" that lacks real relevance and usefulness.

Source: Textbook on News Reporting and Writing by The Missouri Group

Proximity

- Generally, people are more interested in and concerned about what happens close to home.
- When they read or listen to national or international news, they often want to know how it relates to their own community.
- Journalists and scholars are recognizing that communities organized around a particular interest—a sport, a hobby or an issue—are at least as important as geographic communities.

Source: Textbook on News Reporting and Writing by The Missouri Group

Thank you!